

BUS63-6

Launch & Scale — Go-to-Market Strategy

Positioning, motion, pricing, and the first commercial machine

Building a commercial machine that survives the first eighteen months.

Albert School — 22 hours

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1 Product mindset vs feature mindset

Go-to-market (GTM) is the demand-side discipline of turning a validated product into a business that scales. Its starting point is a mindset distinction.

Definition 1 Feature mindset: organizing decisions around what the product does — shipping and accumulating features.

Definition 2 Product mindset: organizing decisions around the demand the product serves — what customers are trying to accomplish and what they will pay for.

The distinction changes every downstream GTM decision:

- **What to build first:** the feature mindset builds what is technically next; the product mindset builds what creates demand.
- **What to charge:** the feature mindset prices to cost or feature count; the product mindset prices to the value delivered to the customer.
- **Who to hire:** the feature mindset hires to ship more; the product mindset hires the commercial profile the chosen motion requires.
- **When to scale:** the feature mindset scales when the product is “ready”; the product mindset scales only when demand evidence justifies it.

2 Customer discovery and demand-side analysis

GTM rests on evidence about demand, gathered through structured customer discovery rather than assumption.

Definition 3 Customer discovery: a structured process of formulating demand hypotheses, designing interviews to test them, and extracting insights that change the GTM plan.

The process has three stages:

- **Hypothesis formulation:** state, as falsifiable claims, who the customer is, what problem they have, and how they currently solve it.
- **Interview design:** write non-leading questions that elicit past behaviour and real problems rather than confirmation of the hypothesis.
- **Insight-to-GTM translation:** convert findings into specific changes to positioning, pricing, motion, or acquisition.

Common pitfall The failure mode is discovery that confirms prior assumptions. Useful discovery changes the plan; discovery that only validates what the founder already believed has been mis-designed.

2.1 Jobs-to-be-Done and Kano

Two framings separate features that create demand from features that merely satisfy expectations.

Definition 4 Jobs-to-be-Done (JTBD): customers “hire” a product to make progress on a job in a given circumstance. The unit of analysis is the job, not the customer demographic or the product feature.

Definition 5 Kano model: features fall into categories by how their presence and absence affect satisfaction — **basic/hygiene** features (expected; their absence dissatisfies, their presence is taken for granted), **performance** features (satisfaction scales with how well they are delivered), and **delighters/differentiators** (unexpected features that create disproportionate satisfaction).

JTBD and Kano together identify which features create demand-side **differentiation** (delighters and strong performance features tied to the job) as opposed to **hygiene factors** that must be present but win nothing. The GTM recommendation is a market-side launch priority — what to lead with — without crossing into supply-side product ownership.

3 Positioning as strategic commitment

Definition 6 Positioning: the deliberate choice of the context in which a product is understood, so that its strengths become obvious to the customers who matter.

Definition 7 Dunford’s Obviously Awesome five components: (1) **competitive alternatives** — what customers would use if the product did not exist; (2) **unique attributes** — what the product has that the alternatives lack; (3) **value** — the benefit those attributes enable; (4) **target customers** — those who care most about that value; (5) **market category** — the frame of reference that makes the value obvious.

Definition 8 Category decision: the choice of which market category the product is understood to belong to. It is the most consequential pre-launch choice, because the category sets the customer’s reference points, expectations, and comparison set.

Definition 9 Category repositioning: moving a product out of a category in which it is directly compared and disadvantaged, into one where its attributes read as strengths, to escape unfavourable direct comparison.

4 GTM motion selection

Definition 10 GTM motion: the dominant mechanism by which the business acquires and converts customers — **sales-led** (humans sell, typically higher-touch), **product-led** (the product itself acquires and converts, e.g. free trial / self-serve), or **marketing-led** (marketing generates and converts demand at scale).

The motion is selected against four decision criteria:

- **Price point:** low prices cannot support high-touch sales; high prices require it.
- **Sales complexity:** complex, multi-stakeholder purchases need sales-led motion; simple purchases suit product-led or marketing-led.
- **Team profile:** the founding team's existing commercial strengths constrain the feasible motion.
- **Stage:** what is appropriate shifts as the company matures.

Common pitfall Motion mismatch — choosing a motion that contradicts the price point, sales complexity, team, or stage — is a characteristic failure mode that can cost roughly eighteen months before the error is recognized and corrected.

5 Pricing at launch

Definition 11 Launch pricing models: **penetration** (low price to win share fast), **skimming** (high initial price captured from early adopters, lowered over time), **freemium** (a free tier that converts to paid), **tiered** (multiple packaged levels), **value-based** (price set to a share of value delivered), and **usage-based** (price scales with consumption).

Price sensitivity is tested before launch rather than assumed.

Definition 12 Van Westendorp price-sensitivity meter: a four-question survey (“too cheap”, “cheap/bargain”, “expensive”, “too expensive”) whose response curves bound an acceptable price range.

Definition 13 Willingness-to-pay (WTP) interviews: qualitative interview methodology that probes what a customer would actually pay and why, surfacing the value drivers behind the number.

Conversion benchmarks differ by pricing structure (e.g. freemium free-to-paid conversion is typically low; tiered and value-based structures convert differently), and a chosen model must be defended against at least one plausible alternative.

6 Distribution strategy

Definition 14 Distribution strategy: the choice of channels through which the product reaches customers, determined by product type, customer segment, and competitive context.

Definition 15 Build vs acquire vs ally: a channel or partnership can be **built** in-house, **acquired**, or accessed through an **alliance** with a partner who already holds the channel — each with different cost, speed, and control.

7 Customer acquisition: pre-PMF vs post-PMF

Definition 16 Product-market fit (PMF): the state in which the product satisfies strong market demand, evidenced by retention and pull rather than by effort alone.

Definition 17 Pre-PMF acquisition levers: **direct outreach**, **community**, **content**, and **referral** — low-scale, often founder-driven levers used to find and learn from early customers.

Pre-PMF and post-PMF acquisition differ structurally. Before PMF the goal is learning and finding the first customers, so acquisition is manual and unscalable by design; after PMF the goal is repeatable, scalable acquisition through paid and systematic levers. Applying post-PMF scaling logic before PMF is reached is premature.

8 Pre-PMF vs post-PMF metrics

The metric set shifts at PMF.

Definition 18 Pre-PMF metrics: **engagement depth**, **retention**, and qualitative signals — measures of whether early users actually find value.

Definition 19 Post-PMF metrics: **CAC** (customer acquisition cost), **LTV** (lifetime value), **payback period** (time to recover CAC), and **growth rate** — measures of whether acquisition is economically scalable.

Once PMF is reached, the commercial machine shifts from optimizing for evidence of value to optimizing for the economics of repeatable acquisition.

9 Scaling discipline

Definition 20 Scaling decision: the judgement that evidence is sufficient to shift from exploratory growth to a scalable, repeatable acquisition engine.

Definition 21 Premature scaling: investing in scale — headcount, paid acquisition, infrastructure — before the positioning, pricing, and channel are validated. It is the dominant early-stage failure mode.

Observable signals of premature scaling include rising CAC without retention, hiring ahead of a repeatable sales process, and spending on channels that have not been shown to convert. Such signals invalidate a decision to scale.

9.1 Test-and-learn iteration

Definition 22 Test-and-learn: post-launch iteration on positioning, pricing, and channel in which each cycle specifies what was tested, what was learned, what changed as a result, and which assumption is now falsified.

10 Building the first commercial machine

The first commercial machine is built deliberately, not improvised.

Definition 23 Founder-led sales protocol: a documented, repeatable selling process run by the founder before any salesperson is hired, capturing the discovery questions, pitch, objections, and conversion steps that work.

Definition 24 First three commercial hires by motion: the selection criteria and profiles for the initial commercial hires depend on the chosen motion — a sales-led motion hires sellers first, a product-led motion hires growth/product-marketing profiles, a marketing-led motion hires demand-generation profiles.

Definition 25 Pipeline structuring: defining the sales pipeline by **stage**, with **conversion rates** between stages and a **cycle length** per stage, so the pipeline can be diagnosed and forecast.

Definition 26 Founder-led to team-led transition: the planned handover from the founder selling personally to a commercial team selling repeatably, which presupposes that the founder-led protocol has been codified.

11 Growth model design

Definition 27 Growth model: a coherent connection of product usage, acquisition, retention, and revenue into a single commercial engine that stakeholders can stress-test.

A growth model is judged on whether its parts cohere — whether acquisition feeds usage, usage drives retention, and retention sustains revenue — and on whether it survives stress-testing of its assumptions.

12 Integrated GTM plan

Definition 28 Integrated GTM plan: a complete plan for a real business model (B2B SaaS, marketplace, DTC physical product, or professional service) comprising positioning, motion, pricing with testable sensitivity, a 100-customer acquisition plan, a 12-month commercial structure, and a growth model connecting product usage, acquisition, retention, and revenue.

The defining requirement is **coherence across elements**: positioning, motion, pricing, acquisition, and commercial structure must be mutually consistent. A practitioner jury tests that coherence and penalises incoherence — for example, a high-touch sales-led motion attached to a low price point, or a positioning that contradicts the chosen acquisition channel.